

Wounded bald eagle flying free



PHOTOS BY YALONDA M. JAMES - yjames@charlotteobserver.com

Carolina Raptor Center staffer Mathias Engelmann and Elizabeth Mackey, a veterinarian from the University of Georgia College of Veterinary Medicine, hand N.C. Rep. Thom Tillis a 1-year-old bald eagle to release at Landsford Canal State Park in Catawba, S.C.

Raptor center celebrates successful rehabilitation

BY LENA WARMACK
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CATAWBA, S.C. — A 1-year-old bald eagle perched on a tree branch at the Landsford Canal State Park after its release Saturday.

The unnamed eagle had spent four months at the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville recovering from gunshot wounds to its left wing and shoulder.

"It was beautiful seeing him take the first flight and getting his balance," said Barbara Nieto of Indian Trail, N.C. "I just hope he finds a peaceful life."

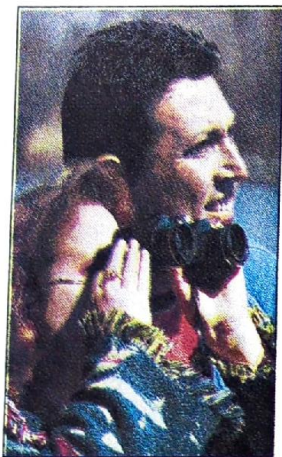
This is the first eagle to be released by the

center this year, and the 34th in its 26-year history.

Over the past three decades, the bald eagle population has rebounded because of state and federal laws that protect them. There are 9,789 bald eagle breeding pairs in the U.S., according to the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service.

The male eagle freed Saturday will develop its signature white head and tail feathers in about four years.

It was found in October along the coast of Bryan County, Ga., with what were apparently serious gunshot wounds — the most common inju-



Barbara and Carlos Nieto of Indian Trail watch a 1-year-old bald eagle fly away after its release on Saturday.

ens for treatment.

In November, he was sent to the Carolina Raptor Center for rehabilitation and re-evaluation of his injuries.

"There was significant damage," said Mathias Engelmann, director of rehabilitation at the center. "Some flight feathers had fallen out. And we weren't sure if they were going to grow back."

It took about a month for the bird to heal and regrow most of its feathers before he was placed in a 100-foot flight cage to strengthen his left wing and shoulder.

About two weeks ago, the center determined that the eagle was ready for release because of how

"We know it will sustain bald eagles because it's got fish, and it's just a really nice location for this bird to thrive," Warren said.

Park manager Al James said two pairs of bald eagles have nested for 14 years at the park, which is covered with tall sweetgum, river birch and sycamore trees - ideal for nesting offspring.

On Saturday, N.C. Rep. Thom Tillis, R-Mecklenburg, cradled the young eagle in his arms with thick leather gloves.

He tossed the eagle toward the sky.

The eagle - with a wingspan of 6 to 7 feet - soared over the Catawba River.

About the Carolina Raptor Center

- The nonprofit bird refuge treats and rehabilitates injured birds of prey, such as eagles, hawks and owls.
- Last year, the center treated 813 birds. Of those, about six to 10 were eagles.
- The center keeps 23 species of raptors on 57 acres that's part of the Latta Plantation Nature Preserve off Beatties Ford Road in Huntersville.
- A group of UNC Charlotte biology faculty and students who wanted to treat and protect raptors established the center in the 1980s.
- More than 13,000 birds have received treatment at the center. And about 5,000 birds have been released.
- Today, the center has expanded to include a rehabilitation and treatment center and educational programs.
- More than 100,000 people visit the center, its programs and off-site exhibits.